4. International political economy—between 1970 and 1980—increasing concern with economic issues made international political economy (IPE) inextricably woven into IR, especially with regard to security issues.[31]

Palmer and Perkins[32] include such topics within the domain of IR such as state system, national power, diplomacy, propaganda, war, imperialism, balance of power, collective security, international organizations, international law, regional conflicts, national interests, nuclear weapon and changing international system.

According to Frankel,[33] the contents of IR must take care of the changes in the international system, i.e., the rise in the number of states, MNCs and terrorist groups; the shift of the major danger spots geographically, from Europe to Middle East and Africa, from the strategic to the economic field; the growing recognition of the need for some form of global or regional regimes, overriding sovereign states. Therefore, the study should include the making of foreign policies, the mutual interactions among states, conflicts, competitions and cooperations among them, national power, diplomacy, propaganda, international system and international organization.

Coloumbis and Wolfe[34] emphasize that the study of IR should involve the approaches to the study of IR, theories of IR, nation-states and nationalism, national power, national interest, foreign policies of nation-states and nationalism, national power, decision making, diplomacy, war, balance of power, international law, international economy, international organizations, functionalism and regional integration, gap between the rich and poor nation-states, new actors in international system, threats facing humankind.

Kal Holsti[35] points out that during the heydays of the Cold War, the field was characterized by three distinct sets of normative concerns or discourses which tried to answer the question ‘what to study?’ They are:

- Security, conflict and war
- Cooperation and the conditions for peace